

Persecution Expected

prc-persecution-expected
Engagement with World · Suffering · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Persecution and suffering for Christ are normal, expected aspects of Christian discipleship in this age.

In plain language

The anchor verses present persecution and suffering for Christ as the expected experience of those who follow him, not as a rare exception. The clearest single statement is 2 Timothy 3:12, where Paul says that all who want to live a godly life in Christ Jesus will be persecuted. The Greek word for all (pantes) leaves out no group, and the verb 'will be persecuted' (diochthesontai) is a plain future, so the text ties hostility directly to the desire to live godly in Christ. In John 15:20 Jesus reasons from himself to his followers. If they persecuted me, they will also persecute you, and a servant is not greater than his master, so the disciples' persecution follows from his own. John 15:18 has already framed the world's hatred (miseo) of the disciples as flowing from its earlier hatred of Christ. In the Beatitudes, Matthew 5:10-12, Jesus calls the persecuted blessed (makarioi) and tells them to rejoice and be glad, because the prophets before them were persecuted in the same way, which sets their experience in a long line rather than treating it as strange. First Peter 4:12 is explicit on the point of expectation. Do not be surprised (me xenizesthe) at the fiery trial (pyrosis) among you, as though something strange were happening to you. Peter then calls suffering (pathema) a sharing in the sufferings of Christ, says the one who suffers as a Christian should not be ashamed but glorify God, and speaks of those who suffer (pascho) according to the will of God. Paul widens the picture in Philippians 1:29 by saying that suffering for Christ has been granted as a gift alongside faith, and Acts 14:22 says it is through many tribulations (thlipsis) that we enter the kingdom of God, attaching necessity to the path. One verse that could seem to qualify the claim, First Peter 4:15, warns against suffering as a wrongdoer, but the very next verse contrasts that with suffering as a Christian, narrowing the kind of suffering in view rather than denying the expectation. The text-level verbs are dense and repeat across many books. The word for persecute (dioko) occurs in around forty five places across the Gospels, Acts, Paul, Hebrews, Peter, and Revelation, and the word for suffer (pascho) in about forty more, so the pattern is not local to one writer. Taken together the words present persecution and suffering as a normal and foreseen part of following Christ in the present age, and the verdict affirms the proposition with strong and consistent support.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G1377	διώκω	dioko	to pursue	45
G2153	εὐσεβῶς	eusebos	piously	2
G2347	θλίψις	thlipsis	pressure	44
G3107	μακάριος	makarios	blessed	50
G3404	μισέω	miseo	to hate	41

G3579	ξενίζω	xenizo	to host	10
G3679	ὀνειδίζω	oneidizo	to revile	9
G3804	πάθημα	pathema	suffering	16
G3958	πάσχω	pascho	to suffer	42
G4451	πύρωσις	pyrosis	burning	3

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The anchor verses present persecution and suffering as the foreseen condition of those who follow Christ. 2 Timothy 3:12 makes it universal with the subject 'all who desire' (pantes hoi thelontes) 'to live godly' (eusebos zen) 'in Christ Jesus' (en Christo Iesou) and the future passive 'will be persecuted' (diochthesontai, an ongoing future passive form meaning the action will be done to them), all who desire to live godly in Christ Jesus will be persecuted, with no exempted class. John 15:20 grounds it in the master-servant relation, 'if they persecuted me, they will also persecute you' (ei eme edioxan kai hymas dioxousin), treating the disciples' persecution as the direct entailment of Christ's. 1 Peter 4:12 issues the present imperative (an ongoing command) 'do not be surprised' (me xenizesthe) at the 'fiery trial' (pyrosis), denying that suffering is foreign, and Matthew 5:10-12 calls the persecuted 'blessed' (makarioi) and sets them in continuity with the prophets. Querying the canon, 'to persecute' (dioko, Strong's G1377) recurs in 45 verses across the Gospels, Acts, Paul, Hebrews, Peter, and Revelation, and 'to suffer' (pascho, Strong's G3958) in 42 verses with the same spread, so the lexical pattern is pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) and dense.

Scripture

2Tim.3.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1377 διώκω, G2153 εὐσεβῶς

Reasoning. The clause 'all who desire to live godly in Christ Jesus will be persecuted' (pantes hoi thelontes eusebos zen en Christo Iesou diochthesontai) places 'all' (pantes) as the subject and the future passive 'will be persecuted' (diochthesontai, the action will be done to them in the future) as the predicate (a noun completing a 'X is Y' statement, here completing the sentence). The universal quantifier 'all' (pantes) with the adverb 'godly' (eusebos) and the qualifier 'in Christ' (en Christo) ties persecution to the very desire to live a godly life in Christ, leaving no exempt category, which is the affirmative core of the proposition.

John.15.18 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3404 μισέω

Reasoning. 'If the world hates you, know that it has hated me before you' (Ei ho kosmos hymas misei, ginostete hoti eme proton hymon memiseken). The present indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact) 'hates' (misei) for the world's hatred of the disciples and the perfect (a completed action whose result still stands) 'has hated' (memiseken) for its prior settled hatred of Christ place the disciples' experience inside Christ's, establishing hostility as the expected backdrop rather than a surprise.

John.15.20 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1377 διώκω

Reasoning. The first-class condition (an 'if-then' clause treating the 'if' as a real case) 'if they persecuted me, they will also persecute you' (ei eme edioxan, kai hymas dioxousin) treats Christ's having been persecuted, in the aorist (a completed past action) 'they persecuted' (edioxan), as the premise and the disciples' being persecuted, in the future 'they will persecute' (dioxousin), as the entailed result. The maxim 'a servant is not greater than his master' (ouk estin doulos meizon tou kyriou autou) makes the servant's persecution follow from the master's by necessity.

Matt.5.10 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1377 διώκω, G3107 μακάριος

Reasoning. 'Blessed are those who have been persecuted for righteousness' sake' (Makarioi hoi dediogmenoi heneken dikaiosynes) uses the perfect passive participle 'those who have been persecuted' (dediogmenoi, a completed action whose result still stands, naming people in a settled state of having been persecuted), joined to the beatitude word 'blessed' (makarioi). Persecution for righteousness is named as a settled condition that carries the blessing and the kingdom, so it is treated as an expected mark of the righteous, not an exception.

Matt.5.11 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3679 ὅνειδίζω, G1377 διώκω

Reasoning. 'Whenever they revile you and persecute you' (Hotan oneidisosin hymas kai dioxosin) uses 'whenever' (hotan) with the aorist subjunctive (a verb form here meaning 'should they do this, completed each time'), framing the reviling and persecuting not as a remote possibility but as a recurring whenever, with the qualifier 'for my sake' (heneken emou), locating the cause in allegiance to Christ.

Matt.5.12 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1377 διώκω

Reasoning. 'Rejoice and be glad' (Chairete kai agalliasathe) commands present rejoicing and exultation, and the clause 'for so they persecuted the prophets' (houtos gar edioxan tous prophetas) sets the disciples' persecution in continuity with the prophets before them. The aorist 'they persecuted' (edioxan, a completed past action) supplies a canonical (Bible-wide) precedent that normalizes the experience.

1Pet.4.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3579 ξενίζω, G4451 πύρωσις

Reasoning. 'Do not be surprised at the fiery trial among you' (Me xenizesthe te en hymin pyrosei) is a present imperative (an ongoing command in plain present-tense form) with the negation 'do not' (me) at the 'fiery trial' (pyrosis) among you, and the appositional phrase 'as though something strange were happening to you' (hos xenou hymin symbainontos) explicitly denies that the trial is foreign. The lexical force is that suffering is to be expected, not regarded as alien.

1Pet.4.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3804 πάθημα

Reasoning. 'Insofar as you share in the sufferings of Christ' (Katho koinoneite tois tou Christou pathemasin) uses 'sufferings' (pathemasin, the plural of pathema) to fold the believers' suffering into Christ's, and 'rejoice' (chairete) with the purpose clause 'so that also at the revelation of his glory you may rejoice' (hina kai en te apokalypsei tes doxes autou charete) treats present suffering as the path to future joy at his revelation, again presenting it as the normal disciple's portion.

1Pet.4.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3958 πάσχω

Reasoning. 'But if anyone suffers as a Christian, let him not be ashamed' (Ei de hos Christianos, me aischnestho). The conditional (an 'if-then' clause) 'if' (ei) with the label 'Christian' (Christianos) ties the suffering directly to the name of the disciple and commands honoring God in it, presupposing that suffering as a Christian is an anticipated rather than aberrant case.

1Pet.4.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3958 πάσχω

Reasoning. 'So then also those who suffer according to the will of God' (Hoste kai hoi paschontes kata to thelema tou theou) closes the unit by speaking of those who suffer according to the will of God, the present participle 'those who are suffering' (paschontes, naming people in the ongoing act of suffering) treating such suffering as an ongoing class within God's will, and directs them to entrust their souls to a faithful Creator. Suffering is thus located inside, not outside, the will of God for the believer.

Phil.1.29 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3958 πάσχω

Reasoning. 'For it has been granted to you for the sake of Christ, not only to believe in him but also to suffer for him' (Hoti hymin echaristhe to hyper Christou, ou monon to eis auton pisteuein alla kai to hyper autou paschein). The verb 'was granted as a gift' (echaristhe) governs both believing in Christ and suffering for him, ranking suffering as a gift on a par with faith, which canonically (across the whole Bible) reinforces that suffering is an expected and given component of discipleship.

Acts.14.22 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2347 θλίψις

Reasoning. 'Through many tribulations we must enter the kingdom of God' (Dia pollon thlipseon dei hemas eiselthein eis ten basileian tou theou). The impersonal 'it is necessary' (dei) with 'through many tribulations' (dia pollon thlipseon) attaches necessity to the believer's path into the kingdom, making affliction not optional but constitutive of entrance, which extends the persecution pattern beyond persecution narrowly to suffering broadly.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Matt.5.11	Matt.10.18	tsk	1
Matt.5.10	Matt.10.23	tsk	1
Matt.5.11	Matt.10.25	tsk	1
1Pet.4.12	1Pet.1.7	tsk	1
1Pet.4.13	1Pet.1.8	tsk	1
1Pet.4.12	1Pet.4.4	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Pet.4.15 · addressed

'Let none of you suffer as a murderer or thief' (Me gar tis hymon paschete hos phoneus e kleptes) could be read as qualifying the proposition by allowing that some suffering is deserved and not for Christ. The verb 'let him suffer' (paschete) is bounded by the comparative 'as' (hos) clauses, so it separates suffering for wrongdoing from suffering as a Christian in verse 16, and thus narrows the kind of suffering in view rather than denying that suffering for Christ is expected.

1Pet.4.17 · addressed

'For the time has come for judgment to begin at the household of God' (Hoti ho kairos tou arxasthai to krima apo tou oikou tou theou) frames the trial as judgment beginning at the household of God, which could be heard as a unique end-time episode rather than ordinary discipleship. The noun 'judgment' (krima) here is the refining trial of believers contrasted with the worse end of the disobedient, so it reinforces rather than restricts the expectation that the godly pass through suffering in this age.

John.16.33 · addressed

'In the world you have tribulation' (En to kosmo thlipsin echete), joined to 'take courage, I have overcome the world' (tharseite, ego nenikeka ton kosmon), could be read as a once-spoken comfort rather than a normative expectation. The present indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact) 'you have' (echete) expresses an ongoing state, and the cause is the world rather than a singular crisis, so the verse generalizes 'tribulation' (thlipsis) as the disciples' standing condition in this age and confirms rather than complicates the proposition.

Concordance traversed

G1377, G3958, G3404, G2153, G3107, G2347, G3579, G3679, G4451, G3804

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

All anchor verses are New Testament and outside the published CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a way of mapping how New Testament manuscript readings descend from one another) scope, which covers only 3 John in this run, so ecm_status is ecm-shadow (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants is consulted but its scope does not yet reach these passages). The bundle provided no variant units for these passages. The marked apparatus readings, such as the bracketed word order at 2 Timothy 3:12 and the spelling and pronoun variants at John 15:18-20 and 1 Peter 4:14-19, do not touch the load-bearing terms 'all' (pantes), 'will be persecuted' (diochthesontai), 'they will persecute' (dioxousin), 'do not be surprised' (me xenizesthe), or 'those who have been persecuted' (dediogmenoi), so the verdict is variant robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. dispensationalism, amillennialism, redemptive-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

amillennialism: affirms · Reads this age as the present overlap in which the church suffers with Christ until his return, so 2 Timothy 3:12 and 1 Peter 4:12-19 describe the normal pilgrim condition of the church throughout the age, directly affirming the proposition.

dispensationalism: affirms · Holds that the present church age precedes a future tribulation, yet still affirms that the godly are persecuted now per the universal 'all' (pantes) of 2 Timothy 3:12 and the master-servant entailment of John 15:20, so persecution remains an expected feature of discipleship in this age even on a futurist reading of later judgment texts.

redemptive-historical: affirms · Sets the disciples' persecution in continuity with the persecuted prophets of Matthew 5:12 and with Christ's own suffering in John 15:20 and 1 Peter 4:13, reading suffering as participation in Christ along the redemptive arc, which affirms the proposition on covenantal grounds.

The lexical data supports the substantive claim across all three lenses. The frameworks diverge on how later judgment and tribulation texts relate to the present age, a divergence the anchor bundle does not need to adjudicate, since each lens affirms that the godly are persecuted in the present age.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem states a descriptive lexical claim, that persecution and suffering for Christ are normal and expected aspects of discipleship in this age, which is asserted in the anchor texts themselves rather than smuggled in by tradition-laden phrasing. 2 Timothy 3:12 supplies the universal 'all' (pantes) and the future 'will be persecuted' (diochthesontai), and 1 Peter 4:12 supplies the explicit denial that such trial is strange, so the proposition can be tested directly on the words. The qualifier in this age carries a mild eschatological (relating to last things or end times) framing but does not preload the verdict, since the texts locate the persecution in the present experience of believers.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Tim.3.12
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1377
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3579
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3958
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	John.15.20
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.5.10
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.5.11
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	1Pet.4.12

License audit

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Reason. MACULA-Greek is licensed CC-BY-NC-4.0, non-commercial and not redistributable in bulk, and SBLGNT-text is under the SBLGNT-EULA, also not redistributable in bulk. Because these two sources were used for the Greek morphology, syntax, and text, the aggregate evidence is not safe to publish.

Source	License	Redistribute
MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes
SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no

Flags

ecm-shadow